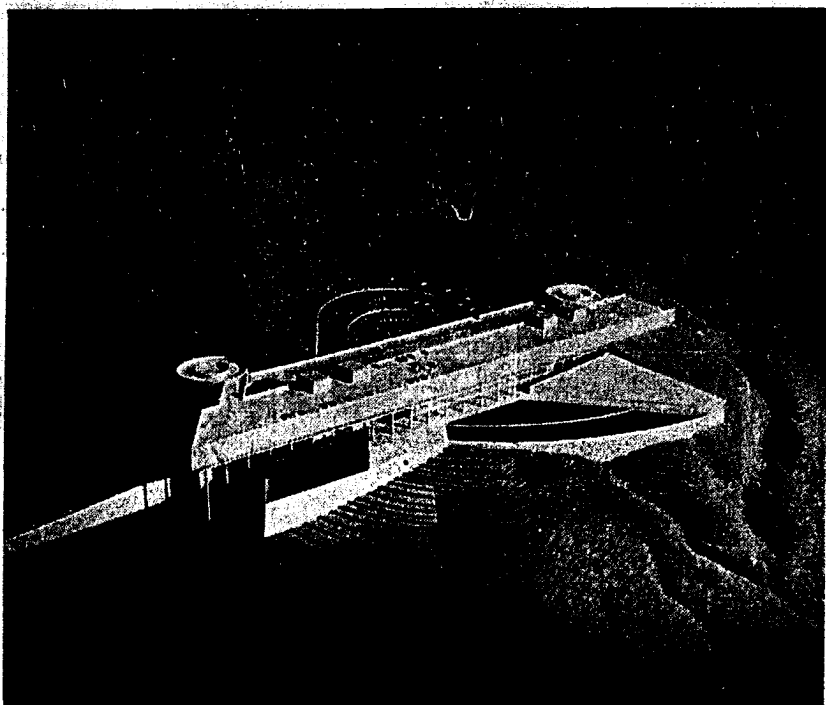




HOME ON THE RANGE — The Architects' Collaborative design for the Johns-Manville headquarters is straightforward and simple, except for parking.

Corporate palace in the wilderness

In the 19th Century, when a robber baron made his millions, the first thing he did was go out and hire a fashionable architect to build him a mansion in the country.

Today the same thing happens, but the rich client has a name like Pepsi-Co. or Connecticut General instead of Vanderbilt or Rockefeller. To the architect, though, the challenge is similar: to arrange the repetitive floors of office space in a stylish way that will reflect the power and wealth of the owner.

Last week, a Cambridge architectural firm, the Architects' Collaborative, won the chance to design what is probably the biggest plum yet among these corporate palaces, the huge new world headquarters of

ARCHITECTURE / By ROBERT CAMPBELL

the Johns-Manville Corporation. Spectacularly sited in the foothills of the Rockies near Denver, the J-M headquarters will house 2000 employees and 1700 cars.

The Architects' Collaborative (TAC for short) got the job by beating out eight other prestigious firms in a national invitational competition sponsored by Johns-Manville. Obviously wanting to make absolutely sure they got the building they wanted, the company spent some \$250,000 on the competition alone, with the building itself budgeted at \$40 million.

TAC's solution, one of the simplest and most straightforward of the

nine entries, puts most of the space in a three-story slab of offices 100 feet long. This long slab is raised up on columns, with smaller reception and display areas tucked away underneath, and a cafeteria, greenhouse and reflecting pool thrusting forward at ground level. Space for parking is carved out of the mountain behind the building, with more cars on the roof reached by two spiral ramps. Taken as a whole, the complex looks big, clean and streamlined, disturbing its natural setting relatively little while still projecting the image the company wants ("progressive, strong, sound and responsible" in the words of its president).

Viewed as a formal exercise, the building can best be seen as the latest evolution of an idea that goes back at least 40 years in modern architecture. LeCorbusier, the great French architect, was the first to float a boxlike volume up on stilts over a landscape that seemed to flow unfettered beneath it, in his Villa Savoye of 1931. Later, in the monastery of LaTourette, he made the floating box out of the monks' cells, and this formal idea was picked up in the Boston

City Hall by Kallmann and McKinnell, where the box became offices and the flowing landscape became a sculptured brick plaza. Since then the idea has been done to death in a thousand hack buildings of every imaginable type. At Johns-Manville it regains new life in a beautifully appropriate application.

As with many competition winners, however, the sculptural pizzazz of the Johns-Manville building shouldn't be looked at too closely. The two spiral ramps, give the complex a lot of vitality, but as a practical matter it seems doubtful whether cars have ever before been asked to spiral up six stories to reach a one-level parking deck. Adding insult, TAC proposes that when the company expands, it put new floors on top, pushing the parking deck and ramps still higher. But the ramps look good and that's what counts. There's always time for rethinking after a competition is won.

To be fair, some of the other architects submitted buildings far less practical than TAC's. An astonishingly unworkable scheme by I.M. Pei consisted of an eight-story underground garage (this in the middle of miles of

open land) surrounded by nine identical towers arranged in a circle, like Stonehenge. This proposal was described by the competition judges as "pretentious, although brilliant," surely the best nutshell summary of Pei to date.

As an architectural problem, the corporate palace in the wilderness seems a little anachronistic at a moment when the healthiest elements in the architectural profession have been moving toward thinking of buildings not as isolated jewels or monuments, but rather as contributing parts of larger social organisms — communities, towns, cities. Yet virtually no architect would turn down such a commission. That being true, the Johns-Manville competition deserves credit as a perfect example of the right way to get a good building.

Competitions are rare in this country, but in Europe they have produced many of the best buildings and have been the chief means of uncovering new talents in architecture. Despite a few ironies, both the way Johns-Manville did it and the building it got deserve to be applauded.

(Mr. Campbell, a regular Globe columnist, is an architect.)